



Rise. Register. Grow.

In business, leaders often talk about a "VUCA" world — one defined by Volatility, Uncertainty, Complexity, and Ambiguity (Bennett & Lemoine, 2014). Prices shift overnight, regulations change, and the road to formalising a small food business can feel impossible to predict. That is exactly the world our traders are operating in. So in this VUCA world, we are here to help you VUKA ;-)

Journey 8: Work Smarter

This is **Journey 08** of the VUKA curriculum: every journey a food trader needs, from checking whether you're ready to grow, right through to scaling into a bigger business, in one consistent, scenario-driven format.

Each lesson takes 3–7 minutes: a real scenario, a quick explanation, one practical tip, a quick challenge, and a badge.

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Journey 8: Work Smarter

"You're already working hard. But is your day actually working for you, or are you just reacting to whatever happens next?"

This journey pulls together the everyday habits, communication, time, teamwork, professionalism, your network, and how you get paid, that separate a business that runs smoothly from one that just runs.

Talk to Customers and Suppliers the Right Way

"A customer says yesterday's food was cold. Do you jump in to explain, or do you actually let them finish first?"

How well you communicate is directly linked to how well your business performs. Good communication builds trust, and trust is what brings a customer back. Greet every customer, a simple "Sawubona," "Dumela," or "Good morning" before talking about price or product sets a respectful tone. Listen before you speak: if a customer complains, let them finish before you respond, this is called active listening, and it's one of the most important skills a small business owner can have. Be clear about price and product every time, don't wait for a customer to ask twice. And keep the same polite, clear approach with suppliers: always confirm what you're ordering, how much it is, and when you'll pay or collect.

 **QUICK TIP** Practise the hard conversations before they happen. Run through a customer complaint or a late-delivery call with a family member so it feels familiar at the moment.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** At your next customer complaint, practise listening fully before you respond.

Complete this and earn:  "Clear Communicator" badge

Structure Your Day So It Doesn't Run You

"Where did your morning actually go? Could you account for every hour of it?"

It isn't a lack of product knowledge that holds most South African traders back, it's time management. On average, small business owners lose close to 96 minutes a day to disorganised or wasted time. A simple daily structure helps: before you leave home, prepare stock, count change, and check your equipment. Arrive early enough to set up before the busiest hour. During trading hours, focus only on selling and serving, don't do admin in the middle of a rush. Use quiet periods to restock, clean, or update your notebook. At the end of the day, count cash, write down what you sold and spent, and plan tomorrow's stock.

 **QUICK TIP** Set a phone alarm for "restock time" and "packing up time," so the day doesn't quietly run away from you.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Write out your ideal daily structure using the five stages above.

Complete this and earn:  "Time Tamer" badge

Build a Team, Even a Small One

"If you got sick tomorrow, would the person helping you know exactly what to do?"

Even a one- or two-person stall benefits from clear roles. Owners with reliable help, even informal help from family, can spend more time on things that actually grow the business, like sourcing better stock or scouting new selling spots. If you work with even one other person, agree out loud, don't just assume who cooks, who serves, and who handles the money. Have one clear "money person" at any given time, to avoid confusion and mistrust. Say thank you and acknowledge good work, it costs nothing and keeps helpers motivated. If you ever expand beyond one or two helpers, agree on simple, fair rules in advance: start and stop times, how pay or profit is split, and what happens if someone doesn't show up.

 **QUICK TIP** A written agreement doesn't need to be formal. A few lines in your notebook is enough to prevent most disputes before they start.



✔ **QUICK CHALLENGE** Write down, even in a few lines, who's responsible for what if you work with anyone else.

Complete this and earn: 🧑‍🔧 "Team Builder" badge

👑 Act Like the Pro You Already Are

"Would a municipal official, a supplier, and a first-time customer all take your business seriously today?"

Around 70% of small businesses in South Africa fail within their first year, often due to a lack of consistency and professional practice, not bad products. Professionalism is what makes people take you seriously even without a fancy shop. Sell from the same spot, at the same times, as much as possible, customers return to what they can rely on. Keep your hands, containers, and stall clean, which is also a legal hygiene requirement. Keep your pricing fair and consistent from customer to customer. If something goes wrong, apologise and offer a fair solution calmly, rather than arguing in public. And keep your word: if you tell a supplier or customer a time, price, or quantity, honour it. Reliability is your reputation.

💡 **QUICK TIP** Pick the one professionalism habit from this lesson that you're weakest on, and focus on just that one this week.

✔ **QUICK CHALLENGE** Pick one professionalism habit from this lesson to start today.

Complete this and earn: 👑 "Pro Mode" badge

🌐 Build a Network That Backs You Up

"Who would warn you if an inspector was heading your way this afternoon?"

Traders with wider networks, other traders, suppliers, community contacts, get better access to information, funding, and support during hard times than those working in isolation. This is especially true at taxi ranks, where many vendors trade side by side. Get to know the traders around you: they're not only competitors, they can share supplier contacts, warn you about inspections, watch your stall, or refer overflow customers your way. Join or form a trader group, many taxi ranks and townships already have informal associations; your municipality's Economic Development office can usually tell you if one exists nearby. Keep supplier contacts saved on your phone with notes on pricing and reliability, and attend free local events run by SEDA or your municipality when you can. WhatsApp groups are a free, low-effort way to stay connected with everyone at once.

💡 **QUICK TIP** Your network is also your early-warning system. A quick WhatsApp message from a neighbouring trader can save you a fine, or a wasted trip.

✔ **QUICK CHALLENGE** Name three people, a trader, a supplier, and a community contact, you could call this week with a business question.

Complete this and earn: 🌐 "Well Connected" badge

💳 Accept Card Payments with Yoco

"A customer wants to tap their card, but you only take cash. Do they buy anyway, or walk to the next stall?"

Nearly 6 million small South African businesses still only accept cash, but many customers now carry less of it, worried about theft. Accepting both cash and card gives you the best of both worlds, and you do not need to be CIPC-registered to sign up with Yoco. Go to yoco.com or download the Yoco app, select "Get Started," and choose Sole Proprietor. Enter your personal details and verify your identity with a photo of your South African ID. Add your trading address (your home address is fine if you trade from there) and a South African bank account in your own name. Choose your card machine, an entry-level Yoco Go costs roughly R800 upfront with a small daily fee only on days you use it, and no monthly fee. Once it arrives, it's already linked to your profile.



 **QUICK TIP** Card payments land in your account the next business day, not instantly, so plan your cash flow around that if you need cash on hand to buy stock.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Go to yoco.com or download the app and check exactly what you'd need to sign up.

Complete this and earn:  "Tap to Trade" badge

Sources for Fact-Checking: Legislation & Regulation

Every legal fact in Journeys 3, 4, and 10 is drawn from current South African legislation and regulator guidance:

- Regulations Governing General Hygiene Requirements for Food Premises (R638 of 2018), under the Foodstuffs, Cosmetics and Disinfectants Act 54 of 1972 — enforced by municipal Environmental Health Departments.
- Regulations Relating to the Labelling and Advertising of Foodstuffs (R146), under the Foodstuffs, Cosmetics and Disinfectants Act 54 of 1972 — Department of Health.
- Businesses Act 71 of 1991 — gov.za.
- Companies Act 71 of 2008 and Companies and Intellectual Property Commission (CIPC) — company registration, business structure conversion, and trade mark registration — cipc.co.za.
- National Regulator for Compulsory Specifications (NRCS), Food and Associated Industries division — canned, smoked, and vacuum-packed products — nrscs.org.za.
- South African Revenue Service (SARS), Small Businesses – Taxpayers, Tax Compliance Status system, and Budget 2026 Frequently Asked Questions (VAT and Turnover Tax threshold changes effective 1 April 2026) — sars.gov.za.
- Unemployment Insurance Act 63 of 2001 and Unemployment Insurance Contributions Act 4 of 2002 — Department of Employment and Labour — labour.gov.za.
- Compensation for Occupational Injuries and Diseases Act 130 of 1993 (COIDA) — Compensation Fund, Department of Employment and Labour — labour.gov.za.
- Basic Conditions of Employment Act 75 of 1997 — Department of Employment and Labour — labour.gov.za.
- National Environmental Management: Waste Act 59 of 2008 and Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) Regulations (Government Notice R.1184, 2020) — Department of Forestry, Fisheries and the Environment — dffe.gov.za.
- Broad-Based Black Economic Empowerment Act 53 of 2003, and the Codes of Good Practice on B-BBEE (Exempted Micro-Enterprise thresholds) — dtic.gov.za.
- Protection of Personal Information Act 4 of 2013 (POPIA) — Information Regulator South Africa — info regulator.org.za.
- Consumer Protection Act 68 of 2008 — online and distance sales provisions — gov.za.
- African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA) — South African implementation guidance — dtic.gov.za.

Note: municipal fees, thresholds, and application processes vary by area and are periodically revised by government and regulators. Verify current requirements directly with the relevant municipality or regulator before publishing final figures in the app.

Sources & Further Reading: Business Practice, Marketing & Financial Literacy

Branding and digital marketing facts in Journeys 6 and 7 draw on the following:

- Cloudfusion (2025). 7 Essential Reasons Why Branding Is Important for Business. Cloudfusion.co.za.
- Dandu, R. (2015). What Is Branding and Why Is It Important for Your Business? Brandingmag.
- Mercer, S. (2026). What to Post When You Have Nothing to Post: 10 Content Ideas for Summerville Businesses. What's Up Summerville.



- Why food photography is important for your food business. candyfoxstudio.com.
- Yolisa Motha (2021). A Guide to Branding a Small Business. iKhokha.

Statistics on South African small business communication, time management, professionalism, networking, record-keeping, and banking (Journeys 1, 2, 8, and 9) are drawn from national small business research. Verify current figures against original sources before publishing final numbers in the app.

Growth-readiness, lending-risk, funding, and stock-management facts in Journeys 1, 2, 5, and 9 draw on the following:

- National Debt Advisors (2021). Stay away from unregistered money-lenders. nationaldebtadvisors.co.za.
- Startup Mag (2025). Scaling Signals: Ten Signs Your Small Business Is Ready to Grow. startupmag.co.za; Lula (2025). 5 Signs Your Business is Ready for Growth Capital. lula.co.za.
- RegInsights (2024). Small Business Funding. regenesys.net/reginsights.
- Graduates24 (n.d.). NYDA Grant Programme Small Business Funding in South Africa. graduates24.com.
- Okhantu (2025). SEDFA Funding 2026: Requirements, Amounts & How to Apply. okhantu.co.za.
- Ready Accounting (2026). Inventory management tips for cost savings and efficiency. readyaccounting.co.za.
- Xtraspace (2024). Small Business Inventory Management in SA: 10 Top Tips. xtraspace.co.za.

Sources & Further Reading: The VUCA Concept

The mission statement on the cover page draws on the following:

- Bennett, N., & Lemoine, G. J. (2014). What VUCA Really Means for You. *Harvard Business Review*, 92(1/2), 27.

